B1 Speaking

Describing people and places

Describe someone you know or a place you love, with the right order of details and plenty of useful adjectives.

Describing people and places comes up in conversations and in almost every speaking exam. A good description moves from general to specific and adds a personal opinion at the end.

Step	People	Places
General	*My uncle is in his fifties and lives in Al Ain.*	*It's a small fishing village on the east coast.*
Appearance	*He's tall, with grey hair and a big smile.*	*There are white houses and a long sandy beach.*
Character / atmosphere	*He's generous and very funny.*	*It's quiet and peaceful, especially in the morning.*
Example	*He always tells jokes at family dinners.*	*You can watch the boats come in at sunset.*
Your feeling	*I really admire him.*	*It's my favourite place to relax.*

Give an example for character words. *She's kind* is fine; *She's kind: she always helps her neighbours with their shopping* sounds much better.

Common mistakes. *What does he look like?* asks about appearance; *What is he like?* asks about character. And say *He has long hair*, not *He has a long hair*.

Practice

1. Begin a description of your best friend with one general sentence.
2. Correct the mistake: My sister has a long black hair.
3. Answer: "What's your brother like?" (character, not appearance)

4. Describe the atmosphere of a busy market in one sentence.

5. Add an example to: My teacher is very patient.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. For example: My best friend, Khalid, is twenty-five and works as an engineer.
2. My sister has long black hair.
3. For example: He's friendly and hard-working, but a bit shy at first.
4. For example: It's noisy and colourful, and it smells of spices and fresh bread.
5. My teacher is very patient: she explains things again and again until everyone understands.